

Q+A

ROLE MODEL

***Bhagyashree** talks about playing Jijabai in Riteish Deshmukh's historical action drama,* Raja Shivaji

PRASHANT SAMTANI

Q. How did this film come your way?

Out of the blue, Riteish called to say that he wanted to narrate a subject. He said the film was about Shivaji Raje and he wanted me to play Jijabai. I said 'yes' before he could even start narrating the script. He reminded me of when Sooraj [Barjatya] had come to narrate *Maine Pyar Kiya* years ago.

Q. What interested you about this role?

Jijabai was the rock behind Chhatrapati and mooted the idea of *swaraj* (self-rule). She was more than a traditional mother and helped shape a whole generation in her kingdom. Being able to play a woman from Indian history who changed the political landscape of the time is something I couldn't miss.

Q. How is Riteish Deshmukh as a director?

What makes Riteish a good director is his calm demeanour. Even when things weren't working out, he'd handle everything calmly. On a set, the whole crew takes their cues from the director and if you have someone who doesn't lose their mind, it makes for a healthy work atmosphere.

Q. The industry has changed a lot since your 1989 debut. What is one change you are happy to see and one that you wish hadn't happened?

I love that we get bound scripts in hand. It's so much easier to prepare before you go on set because you can create back stories and rehearse dialogues. This means that you don't waste time on set.

—With Karishma Upadhyay